

Χοιρίλος ὁ Σάμιος

Choerilus of Samos and the Epic Beyond Homer

eul_aid: emy

Period: [Κλασική](#) [Classical](#)
Dialect: [Ἑπική](#) [Epic](#) (Homeric)
Domain: [Ἔπος](#) [Epic](#)
Format: [Ἑμμετρος](#) [Verse](#)

Choerilus of Samos was a Greek epic poet who lived during the 5th century BCE. He is known for seeking patronage from powerful rulers of his time, including King Archelaus of Macedon and, most famously, the Spartan general Lysander after the Peloponnesian War. His major contribution was attempting to adapt traditional epic poetry to contemporary history.

His most significant work was the *Persica*, an epic poem about the Persian Wars. This represented a notable shift from mythological subjects to recent historical events. He also wrote a poem on Spartan history and one on the founding of his home island, Samos, but these are lost. Only fragments of the *Persica* survive.

According to modern scholars, Choerilus holds a minor but interesting place in literary history. His work is seen as an early experiment in historical epic, expanding the genre's scope. Ancient critics like Aristotle and Horace often criticized his poetic style, but his attempt to write a grand epic about recent history is considered a forerunner to later developments in Hellenistic poetry. His life reflects the changing role of poets, who increasingly depended on the patronage of military and political leaders rather than city-states.

Works (3)

- [Ἑπικά Ἀποσπάσματα](#) · [Epic Fragments](#) · 62 passages
- [Ἀποσπάσματα καὶ Τίτλοι](#) · [Fragments and Titles](#) · 21 passages
- [Ἀμφίβολα Ἀποσπάσματα Χοιρίλου Ἰασίου](#) · [Fragments on Wine](#) · 5 passages